

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Lok Adalats and Other Courts - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Lok Adalats and Other Courts - Complete Deep-Reviewed Learning Session

Legal/current control date: 29 August 2026 (Asia/Kolkata)

Source discipline: The current pecuniary ceiling, notified public utility services, institution counts and commencement status are never frozen without a dated official source. The reviewed g2 generation remains immutable.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

Subject: Polity · **Tier:** Core · **GS Paper:** GS-II **Official clause:** "Structure, organization and functioning of the Executive and the Judiciary" and "mechanisms, laws, institutions and Bodies constituted for the protection and betterment of these vulnerable sections." **Grounded in:** Constitution of India, Art 39A; Legal Services Authorities Act 1987; Family Courts Act 1984; Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008; M. Laxmikanth, *Courseware on Indian Polity*, Eighth Edition (2026), Ch. 38. **Status legend:** FACT: constitutional/settled static fact · □ statute/rule · □□ judicial holding · ANALYSIS: analytical inference/current implementation caveat. **Core firewall:** This is the consolidated owner for legal-services institutions, ordinary and Permanent Lok Adalats, Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas. Judiciary/body owners should cross-link, not reproduce these capsules. It is independently sufficient for Prelims and 10/15/20-mark Mains; no Advanced companion is required.

SESSION 1 - CONSTITUTIONAL ANCHOR: ACCESS TO JUSTICE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or other disability does not deny access to justice.

Technical definition: □□ The Supreme Court has linked meaningful legal aid and speedy justice to fair procedure under Article 21.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

FACT: Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or other disability does not deny access to justice.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Constitutional anchor
- access to justice
- Article 39A
- Article 21
- Article
- The Supreme Court

How to use them: Frame the answer through Constitutional anchor; define access to justice, connect Article 39A with Article 21 to explain the mechanism, and use Article for the decisive comparison or qualification.

FACT: Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or other disability does not deny access to justice.

□□ The Supreme Court has linked meaningful legal aid and speedy justice to fair procedure under Article 21.

ANALYSIS: Article 39A is a Directive Principle, but statutes and rights jurisprudence give operational content to its access-to-justice objective.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CONSTITUTIONAL ANCHOR: ACCESS TO JUSTICE

START / CONCEPT: Constitutional anchor: access to justice

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Constitutional anchor · access to justice · Article 39A · Article 21 · Article · The Supreme Court

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Supreme Court has linked meaningful legal aid and speedy justice to fair procedure under Article 21.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: ANALYSIS: Article 39A is a Directive Principle, but statutes and rights jurisprudence give operational content to its access-to-justice objective.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: FACT: Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: FACT: Article 39A directs the State to secure a legal system promoting justice on equal opportunity and to provide free legal aid so that economic or other disability does not deny access to justice.

SESSION 2 - LEGAL-SERVICES AUTHORITIES: INSTITUTIONAL LADDER

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Terminology trap: The statutory abbreviation is ordinarily SLSA (State Legal Services Authority), not “SALSA”.

Technical definition: The authority must also be satisfied that there is a prima facie case to prosecute or defend.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Terminology trap: The statutory abbreviation is ordinarily SLSA (State Legal Services Authority), not “SALSA”.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Legal-services authorities
- institutional ladder
- Terminology trap
- SLSA
- NALSA
- Supreme Court Committee

How to use them: Frame the answer through Legal-services authorities; define institutional ladder, connect Terminology trap with SLSA to explain the mechanism, and use NALSA for the decisive comparison or qualification.

□ The Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates this structure:



Institution	Key position
NALSA	Lays down policy/principles and frames effective/economical legal-services schemes; Patron-in-Chief is the CJI; Executive Chairman is a serving/retired Supreme Court judge nominated in the statutory manner
Supreme Court Committee	Provides and administers legal services for matters before the Supreme Court
State Authority	Implements Central policy and coordinates State legal services/Lok Adalats; Patron-in-Chief is the Chief Justice of the High Court
High Court Committee	Provides legal services for matters before the High Court
District Authority	Implements programmes and coordinates Taluk activity; District Judge is chairman
Taluk Committee	Coordinates services and Lok Adalats at taluk/mandal level

Terminology trap: The statutory abbreviation is ordinarily **SLSA** (State Legal Services Authority), not “SALSA”. District and Taluk bodies are commonly abbreviated DLSA and TLSC.

Eligibility for free legal services

□ Section 12 covers specified vulnerable groups, including members of SC/ST, trafficking/begar victims, women or children, persons with disability, disaster/violence victims, industrial workmen, persons in custody and persons below the prescribed income limit. The authority must also be satisfied that there is a prima facie case to prosecute or defend.

Trap: Free legal aid is broader than representation in a criminal trial and is not confined to persons below an income threshold; several statutory categories are status-based.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - LEGAL-SERVICES AUTHORITIES: INSTITUTIONAL LADDER

START / CONCEPT: Legal-services authorities: institutional ladder

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Legal-services authorities · institutional ladder · Terminology trap · SLSA · NALSA · Supreme Court Committee

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates this structure.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Trap: Free legal aid is broader than representation in a criminal trial and is not confined to persons below an income threshold; several statutory categories are status-based.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Free legal aid is broader than representation in a criminal trial and is not confined to.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Terminology trap: The statutory abbreviation is ordinarily SLSA (State Legal Services Authority), not "SALSA".

SESSION 3 - ORDINARY LOK ADALAT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Master trap: Finality of an agreed award does not authorise a Lok Adalat to impose a merits decision when compromise fails.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: These formats do not alter the ordinary Lok Adalat's consent-based legal character.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Master trap: Finality of an agreed award does not authorise a Lok Adalat to impose a merits decision when compromise fails.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Ordinary Lok Adalat
- Master trap
- National/State/District Lok Adalat
- General sittings across jurisdictions
- Mobile Lok Adalat
- Travels to improve access

How to use them: Frame the answer through Ordinary Lok Adalat; define Master trap, connect National/State/District Lok Adalat with General sittings across jurisdictions to explain the mechanism, and use Mobile Lok Adalat for the decisive comparison or qualification.

3.1 Nature and jurisdiction

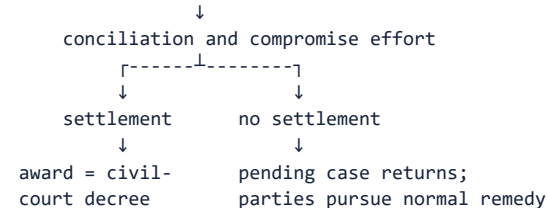
□ Authorities/committees organise Lok Adalats with serving/retired judicial officers and other prescribed persons. They may handle:

- a pending case; or
- a pre-litigation matter falling within a court's jurisdiction,

but not an offence that is legally non-compoundable.

3.2 Process and effect

Referral / joint pre-litigation application



□ The ordinary Lok Adalat:

- seeks an amicable settlement and is guided by justice, equity, fair play and legal principles;
- **cannot compel a compromise or adjudicate the dispute on merits;**
- makes an award when parties settle;
- gives the award the status of a civil-court decree;
- makes the award final and binding, with no statutory appeal; and
- enables refund of court fee in a referred case.

□□ An award based on compromise is ordinarily challengeable only through constitutional review on limited grounds such as absence of genuine consent/fraud-not by a statutory appeal.

Master trap: Finality of an agreed award does not authorise a Lok Adalat to impose a merits decision when compromise fails.

3.3 Forms

Form	Feature
National/State/District Lok Adalat	General sittings across jurisdictions
Mobile Lok Adalat	Travels to improve access
Mega/continuous/daily Lok Adalat	Administrative formats for volume or regular settlement
E-Lok Adalat	Technology-enabled settlement format

ANALYSIS: These formats do not alter the ordinary Lok Adalat's consent-based legal character.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ORDINARY LOK ADALAT

START / CONCEPT: Ordinary Lok Adalat

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v

EXACT TERMS: Ordinary Lok Adalat • Master trap • National/State/District Lok Adalat • General sittings across jurisdictions • Mobile Lok Adalat • Travels to improve access

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: An award based on compromise is ordinarily challengeable only through constitutional review on limited grounds such as absence of genuine consent/fraud-not by a statutory appeal.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: ANALYSIS: These formats do not alter the ordinary Lok Adalat's consent-based legal character.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: but not an offence that is legally non-compoundable.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Master trap: Finality of an agreed award does not authorise a Lok Adalat to impose a merits decision when compromise fails.

SESSION 4 - PERMANENT LOK ADALAT (PLA)

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: □ A Permanent Lok Adalat is established under the Legal Services Authorities Act for one or more public utility services.

Technical definition: Technically, Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA) is analysed by relating public utility services to □ A Permanent Lok Adalat, then testing the relationship through Permanent Lok Adalat and Legal Services Authorities Act.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

□ A Permanent Lok Adalat is established under the Legal Services Authorities Act for one or more public utility services.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA)
- public utility services
- □ A Permanent Lok Adalat
- Permanent Lok Adalat
- Legal Services Authorities Act
- It

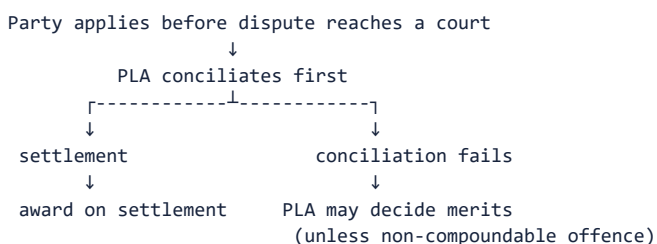
How to use them: Frame the answer through Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA); define public utility services, connect □ A Permanent Lok Adalat with Permanent Lok Adalat to explain the mechanism, and use Legal Services Authorities Act for the decisive comparison or qualification.

□ A Permanent Lok Adalat is established under the Legal Services Authorities Act for one or more **public utility services**. It is permanent in institution and works principally at the pre-litigation stage.

4.1 Public utility services

Statutory illustrations include transport, postal/telephone, supply of power/light/water, public conservancy/sanitation, hospital/dispensary and insurance services, plus notified services.

4.2 Hybrid process



□ Key distinctions:

- jurisdiction is pre-litigation and sector-specific;
- a party cannot invoke another court for that dispute after applying while PLA proceedings continue;
- PLA first conducts conciliation;
- if conciliation fails, it may decide the dispute on merits, subject to statutory exclusions and the Central Government's notified pecuniary limit;
- its award is final, binding, deemed a civil-court decree and not to be called in question in an original suit/application/execution proceeding;
- it is guided by natural justice, objectivity, fair play, equity and other principles of justice, and is not bound by the CPC or Evidence Act.

Trap: Do not attach a stale rupee ceiling to the Act. The Central Government may revise the limit by notification; verify the current notification for a current-affairs answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - PERMANENT LOK ADALAT (PLA)

START / CONCEPT: Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA)

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v

EXACT TERMS: Permanent Lok Adalat (PLA) • public utility services • A Permanent Lok Adalat • Permanent Lok Adalat • Legal Services Authorities Act • It

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: jurisdiction is pre-litigation and sector-specific; a party cannot invoke another court for that dispute after applying while PLA proceedings continue; PLA first conducts conciliation; if conciliation fails, it may decide the dispute on merits, subject to statutory exclusions and the Central Government's notified pecuniary limit; its award is final, binding, deemed a civil-court decree and not to be called in question in an original suit/application/execution proceeding; it is guided by natural justice, objectivity, fair play, equity and other principles of justice, and is not bound by the CPC or Evidence Act.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Trap: Do not attach a stale rupee ceiling to the Act.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not attach a stale rupee ceiling to the Act. The Central Government may revise the.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: A Permanent Lok Adalat is established under the Legal Services Authorities Act for one or more public utility services.

SESSION 5 - ORDINARY LOK ADALAT VERSUS PERMANENT LOK ADALAT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: An ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise; a Permanent Lok Adalat is a pre-litigation public-utility forum that may adjudicate only after its statutory conciliation stage fails.

Technical definition: An ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise; a Permanent Lok Adalat is a pre-litigation public-utility forum that may adjudicate only after its statutory conciliation stage fails.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

An ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise; a Permanent Lok Adalat is a pre-litigation public-utility forum that may adjudicate only after its statutory conciliation stage fails.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat
- Statutory route
- Ch. VI, 1987 Act
- Ch. VI-A, inserted in 2002
- Institution
- Organised sittings

How to use them: Frame the answer through Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat; define Statutory route, connect Ch. VI, 1987 Act with Ch. VI-A, inserted in 2002 to explain the mechanism, and use Institution for the decisive comparison or qualification.

The two institutions share statutory finality but not the same jurisdiction or decisional power. An ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise; a Permanent Lok Adalat is a pre-litigation public-utility forum that may adjudicate only after its statutory conciliation stage fails.

Axis	Ordinary Lok Adalat	Permanent Lok Adalat
Statutory route	Ch. VI, 1987 Act	Ch. VI-A, inserted in 2002
Institution	Organised sittings	Standing body
Disputes	Pending or pre-litigation within court jurisdiction	Pre-litigation public-utility disputes
Settlement method	Conciliation/compromise only	Conciliation first
If settlement fails	No merits adjudication	May adjudicate merits
Criminal bar	Non-compoundable offences excluded	Same exclusion
Award	Deemed decree; final and binding	Deemed decree; final and binding

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - ORDINARY LOK ADALAT VERSUS PERMANENT LOK ADALAT

START / CONCEPT: Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Ordinary Lok Adalat versus Permanent Lok Adalat · Statutory route · Ch. VI, 1987 Act · Ch. VI-A, inserted in 2002 · Institution · Organised sittings

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The operative mechanism is that an ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that an ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: an ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: An ordinary Lok Adalat depends on compromise; a Permanent Lok Adalat is a pre-litigation public-utility forum that may adjudicate only after its statutory conciliation stage fails.

SESSION 6 - FAMILY COURTS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: □ The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement of family/matrimonial disputes.

Technical definition: Technically, Family Courts is analysed by relating Establishment to Jurisdiction, then testing the relationship through Primary approach and Procedure.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

- The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement of family/matrimonial disputes.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Family Courts
- Establishment
- Jurisdiction
- Primary approach
- Procedure
- Privacy

How to use them: Frame the answer through Family Courts; define Establishment, connect Jurisdiction with Primary approach to explain the mechanism, and use Procedure for the decisive comparison or qualification.

□ The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement of family/matrimonial disputes.

Feature	Position
Establishment	State Government, after consultation with High Court; mandatory for specified cities/towns above the statutory population threshold and discretionary elsewhere
Jurisdiction	Matrimonial status, property between spouses, legitimacy, maintenance, guardianship/custody/access and connected family disputes
Primary approach	Endeavour toward settlement before adjudication where consistent with the case
Procedure	Flexible statutory procedure; may receive material that assists effective resolution
Privacy	Proceedings may be held in camera and must be so held if either party desires
Lawyers	No right as of course to legal representation; court may seek legal-expert assistance
Appeal	To High Court from a non-interlocutory judgment/order, subject to statutory exclusions

ANALYSIS: Specialisation and conciliation do not remove judicial fairness. Family Courts exercise statutory judicial power and differ from compromise-only ordinary Lok Adalats.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FAMILY COURTS

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START / CONCEPT: Family Courts
|
v
EXACT TERMS: Family Courts • Establishment • Jurisdiction • Primary approach • Procedure • Privacy
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: Specialisation and conciliation do not remove judicial fairness.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement...
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement...
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The Family Courts Act 1984 provides specialised courts for conciliation and speedy settlement of family/matrimonial disputes.

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SESSION 7 - GRAM NYAYALAYAS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp or Lok Adalat.

Technical definition: ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp or Lok Adalat.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp or Lok Adalat.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Gram Nyayalayas
- Establishment
- Level
- Presiding officer
- Jurisdiction

- Territorial access

How to use them: Frame the answer through Gram Nyayalayas; define Establishment, connect Level with Presiding officer to explain the mechanism, and use Jurisdiction for the decisive comparison or qualification.

□ The Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008 seeks doorstep justice in rural areas through courts of first instance.

Design element	Position
Establishment	State Government, after consultation with High Court; statutory wording is enabling and implementation is State-dependent
Level	Intermediate Panchayat or group of contiguous Panchayats; headquarters may be mobile
Presiding officer	Nyayadhikari, appointed by State Government in consultation with High Court; qualified for appointment as Judicial Magistrate First Class
Jurisdiction	Specified criminal offences and civil disputes in the Schedules; limits may be altered through statutory process
Territorial access	Mobile court may hold proceedings close to where parties reside/cause arose
Settlement	Endeavour to assist conciliation in civil disputes; conciliators may be used
Procedure	Summary orientation, natural justice and statutory flexibility
Appeals	Criminal appeal to Court of Session; civil appeal to District Court, subject to statutory exceptions

ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp or Lok Adalat. Current counts and operational coverage vary and require dated official verification.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - GRAM NYAYALAYAS

START / CONCEPT: Gram Nyayalayas

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Gram Nyayalayas • Establishment • Level • Presiding officer • Jurisdiction • Territorial access

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The operative mechanism is that ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp...

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp...

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: ANALYSIS: A Gram Nyayalaya is a statutory court-not a village panchayat, khap, mediation camp or Lok Adalat.

SESSION 8 - COMPARATIVE INSTITUTION MAP

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Forum choice depends on the source of jurisdiction, need for consent, power to decide merits and available appeal or review.

Technical definition: Technically, Comparative institution map is analysed by relating Ordinary Lok Adalat to Settlement, then testing the relationship through Yes and No.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Forum choice depends on the source of jurisdiction, need for consent, power to decide merits and available appeal or review.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Comparative institution map
- Ordinary Lok Adalat
- Settlement
- Yes
- No
- No statutory appeal; limited judicial review

How to use them: Frame the answer through Comparative institution map; define Ordinary Lok Adalat, connect Settlement with Yes to explain the mechanism, and use No for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Forum choice depends on the source of jurisdiction, need for consent, power to decide merits and available appeal or review. The same access-to-justice objective can therefore produce very different legal consequences.

Institution	Primary function	Consent needed for outcome?	Can decide merits?	Appeal/control
Ordinary Lok Adalat	Settlement	Yes	No	No statutory appeal; limited judicial review
Permanent Lok Adalat	Public-utility pre-litigation conciliation/adjudication	Not for post-failure merits award	Yes	Statutory finality; constitutional review remains
Family Court	Specialised family adjudication + conciliation	Not for judgment	Yes	Statutory High Court appeal with exclusions
Gram Nyayalaya	Rural first-instance court	Not for judgment	Yes	Session/District appellate routes

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COMPARATIVE INSTITUTION MAP

START / CONCEPT: Comparative institution map

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Comparative institution map • Ordinary Lok Adalat • Settlement • Yes • No • No statutory appeal; limited judicial review

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The operative mechanism is that forum choice depends on the source of jurisdiction, need for consent, power to decide...

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The same access-to-justice objective can therefore produce very different legal consequences.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the same access-to-justice objective can therefore produce very different legal consequences.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Forum choice depends on the source of jurisdiction, need for consent, power to decide merits and available appeal or review.

SESSION 9 - OTHER COURTS AND JUSTICE-DELIVERY DESIGNS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Other courts and justice-delivery designs comprises Other courts, justice-delivery designs and Fast Track Courts as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Other courts and justice-delivery designs is analysed by relating Other courts to justice-delivery designs, then testing the relationship through Fast Track Courts and Government/finance-supported scheme implemented through States and High Courts.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Other courts and justice-delivery designs comprises Other courts, justice-delivery designs and Fast Track Courts as its core connected dimensions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Other courts
- justice-delivery designs
- Fast Track Courts
- Government/finance-supported scheme implemented through States and High Courts
- Additional capacity for selected pending cases
- Special Courts

How to use them: Frame the answer through Other courts; define justice-delivery designs, connect Fast Track Courts with Government/finance-supported scheme implemented through States and High Courts to explain the mechanism, and use Additional capacity for selected pending cases for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Design	Legal source	Core function	UPSC distinction
Fast Track Courts	Government/finance-supported scheme implemented through States and High Courts	Additional capacity for selected pending cases	Not a separate constitutional species or uniform permanent court
Special Courts	Particular statute or valid notification	Trial/adjudication of a defined offence, person or subject	Jurisdiction depends on the parent law
Commercial Courts	Commercial Courts Act 2015, as amended	Specified-value commercial disputes with case-management and pre-institution processes	Statutory civil courts, not tribunals or Lok Adalats
Evening/Morning Courts	High Court/State administrative design under ordinary court authority	Extend hearing hours for suitable minor matters	Administrative format, not a new constitutional hierarchy
Family Courts	Family Courts Act 1984	Family adjudication plus settlement orientation	Judicial decision remains available
Gram Nyayalayas	Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008	Local/mobile first-instance justice	Statutory court with appeals

ANALYSIS: A “special”, “fast”, “commercial” or “evening” label identifies a design or jurisdiction. It does not by itself answer appointment, procedure, appeal or constitutional status.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - OTHER COURTS AND JUSTICE-DELIVERY DESIGNS

START / CONCEPT: Other courts and justice-delivery designs

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Other courts · justice-delivery designs · Fast Track Courts · Government/finance-supported scheme implemented through States and High Courts · Additional capacity for selected pending cases · Special Courts

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: It does not by itself answer appointment, procedure, appeal or constitutional status.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that it does not by itself answer appointment, procedure, appeal or constitutional status.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: it does not by itself answer appointment, procedure, appeal or constitutional status.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Other courts and justice-delivery designs comprises Other courts, justice-delivery designs and Fast Track Courts as its core connected dimensions.

SESSION 10 - MEDIATION ACT 2023 INTERFACE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: □ The Mediation Act 2023 supplies a general statutory framework for mediation, including pre-litigation, institutional, online and community-mediation concepts, mediated-settlement agreements, confidentiality and enforcement/challenge rules.

Technical definition: The Commercial Courts Act's pre-institution mediation route and the Mediation Act must not be collapsed into the Lok Adalat regime.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Commercial Courts Act's pre-institution mediation route and the Mediation Act must not be collapsed into the Lok Adalat regime.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Mediation Act 2023 interface
- The Mediation Act 2023
- The Mediation Act
- Its
- The Commercial Courts Act's
- Mediation Act

How to use them: Frame the answer through Mediation Act 2023 interface; define The Mediation Act 2023, connect The Mediation Act with Its to explain the mechanism, and use The Commercial Courts Act's for the decisive comparison or qualification.

□ The Mediation Act 2023 supplies a general statutory framework for mediation, including pre-litigation, institutional, online and community-mediation concepts, mediated-settlement agreements, confidentiality and enforcement/challenge rules. Its commencement, rules and any sectoral exclusions must be checked provision by provision on the control date.

MEDIATION

neutral facilitates party-made settlement

#

ORDINARY LOK ADALAT

statutory forum records compromise as award/deemed decree

#

PERMANENT LOK ADALAT

conciliation first; eligible public-utility dispute may then be decided on merits

#

COURT / TRIBUNAL

authoritative adjudication under jurisdiction and appeal/review rules

The Commercial Courts Act's pre-institution mediation route and the Mediation Act must not be collapsed into the Lok Adalat regime. Settlement remains party-made in mediation; an ordinary Lok Adalat award follows compromise; a PLA has a limited post-conciliation adjudicatory power.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MEDIATION ACT 2023 INTERFACE

START / CONCEPT: Mediation Act 2023 interface

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Mediation Act 2023 interface · The Mediation Act 2023 · The Mediation Act · Its · The Commercial Courts Act's · Mediation Act

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Its commencement, rules and any sectoral exclusions must be checked provision by provision on the control date.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The Mediation Act 2023 supplies a general statutory framework for mediation, including pre-litigation, institutional, online and community-mediation concepts, mediated-settlement agreements, confidentiality and enforcement/challenge rules.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: an ordinary Lok Adalat award follows compromise.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The Commercial Courts Act's pre-institution mediation route and the Mediation Act must not be collapsed into the Lok Adalat regime.

SESSION 11 - COURTS, TRIBUNALS AND ADR

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Courts, tribunals and ADR comprises Courts, tribunals and ADR as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Technically, Courts, tribunals and ADR is analysed by relating Courts to tribunals, then testing the relationship through ADR and Constitution/statute and judicial hierarchy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Courts, tribunals and ADR comprises Courts, tribunals and ADR as its core connected dimensions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Courts
- tribunals
- ADR
- Constitution/statute and judicial hierarchy
- Statute under constitutional limits
- Contract/statute/court referral

How to use them: Frame the answer through Courts; define tribunals, connect ADR with Constitution/statute and judicial hierarchy to explain the mechanism, and use Statute under constitutional limits for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Axis	Court	Tribunal	ADR/mediation	Lok Adalat
Source	Constitution/statute and judicial hierarchy	Statute under constitutional limits	Contract/statute/court referral	Legal Services Authorities Act
Primary role	Adjudication	Specialised adjudication	Facilitated/party-chosen resolution	Statutory settlement; PLA hybrid
Binding outcome without consent	Yes	Yes	Generally no mediated settlement without consent	Ordinary: no; PLA: yes after failed conciliation within scope
Appeal/review	Hierarchical/statutory	Statutory appeal plus constitutional review	Enforcement/challenge under governing law	Statutory finality plus limited constitutional review

Trap: “Alternative forum” does not mean identical power. Consent, subject matter, pre-litigation status, merits power, enforcement and review must be tested separately.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - COURTS, TRIBUNALS AND ADR

START / CONCEPT: Courts, tribunals and ADR

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Courts · tribunals · ADR · Constitution/statute and judicial hierarchy · Statute under constitutional limits · Contract/statute/court referral

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Consent, subject matter, pre-litigation status, merits power, enforcement and review must be tested separately.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Trap: “Alternative forum” does not mean identical power.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: “Alternative forum” does not mean identical power. Consent, subject matter, .

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Courts, tribunals and ADR comprises Courts, tribunals and ADR as its core connected dimensions.

SESSION 12 - LEADING CASES AND LEGAL EFFECTS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: ANALYSIS: Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism.

Technical definition: Technically, Leading cases and legal effects is analysed by relating Leading cases to legal effects, then testing the relationship through *Hussainara Khatoon (1979) v. State of Bihar* and *Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction (2010)*.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

ANALYSIS: Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Leading cases
- legal effects
- *Hussainara Khatoon (1979) v. State of Bihar*
- *Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction (2010)*
- Structured guidance on court referral to ADR processes
- *InterGlobe Aviation v. N. Satchidanand (2011)*

How to use them: Frame the answer through Leading cases; define legal effects, connect *Hussainara Khatoon (1979) v. State of Bihar* with *Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction (2010)* to explain the mechanism, and use Structured guidance on court referral to ADR processes for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Decision	Decision year	Exam-safe holding/use
<i>Hussainara Khatoon (1979) v. State of Bihar</i>	1979	Speedy justice and legal assistance are integral to fair procedure under Art 21
<i>State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008)</i>	2008	Ordinary Lok Adalat has no adjudicatory role; award must rest on compromise
<i>Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction (2010)</i>	2010	Structured guidance on court referral to ADR processes

Decision	Decision year	Exam-safe holding/use
<i>InterGlobe Aviation v. N. Satchidanand (2011)</i>	2011	Ordinary Lok Adalat and Permanent Lok Adalat are legally distinct; merits power cannot be casually transferred
<i>Bar Council of India v. Union of India (2012)</i>	2012	Upheld the PLA public-utility conciliation-cum-adjudication design
<i>Patil Automation v. Rakheja Engineers (2022)</i>	2022	Commercial pre-institution mediation requirement is mandatory where the statutory urgent-relief exception does not apply
<i>Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama (2022)</i>	2022	Clarified PLA conciliation procedure and its limited power to decide an eligible dispute after conciliation fails

ANALYSIS: Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism. A decision about commercial mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat or PLA cannot be applied as if all three were the same forum.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - LEADING CASES AND LEGAL EFFECTS

START / CONCEPT: Leading cases and legal effects

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Leading cases • legal effects • Hussainara Khatoon (1979) v. State of Bihar • Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction (2010) • Structured guidance on court referral to ADR processes • InterGlobe Aviation v. N. Satchidanand (2011)

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: A decision about commercial mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat or PLA cannot be applied as if all three were the same forum.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that ANALYSIS: Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: ANALYSIS: Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: ANALYSIS: Case use must track the exact statutory mechanism.

SESSION 13 - CONSTITUTIONAL SIGNIFICANCE AND IMPLEMENTATION LIMITS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The constitutional test is affordable access with voluntariness, fairness and review against illegality.

Technical definition: settlement systems risk pressure or unequal bargaining if consent is not real; specialised/local institutions need judges, staff, awareness and infrastructure; statutory finality cannot cure jurisdictional error or denial of natural justice; low utilisation or uneven State implementation may prevent designed access from becoming actual access.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The constitutional test is affordable access with voluntariness, fairness and review against illegality.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Constitutional significance
- implementation limits
- with
- ANALYSIS: ADR

- **The constitutional test**
- **Constitutional significance and implementation limits**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Constitutional significance; define implementation limits, connect with ANALYSIS: ADR to explain the mechanism, and use The constitutional test for the decisive comparison or qualification.

Advantages

- lowers cost, distance and procedural complexity;
- improves access for vulnerable litigants;
- promotes conciliation where continuing relationships matter;
- diverts suitable disputes from regular courts;
- combines legal aid with institutional access.

Limits

- settlement systems risk pressure or unequal bargaining if consent is not real;
- specialised/local institutions need judges, staff, awareness and infrastructure;
- statutory finality cannot cure jurisdictional error or denial of natural justice;
- low utilisation or uneven State implementation may prevent designed access from becoming actual access.

ANALYSIS: ADR is a complement, not a wholesale substitute, for independent courts. The constitutional test is affordable access **with** voluntariness, fairness and review against illegality.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CONSTITUTIONAL SIGNIFICANCE AND IMPLEMENTATION LIMITS

START / CONCEPT: Constitutional significance and implementation limits

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Constitutional significance · implementation limits · with · ANALYSIS: ADR · The constitutional test · Constitutional significance and implementation limits

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: ANALYSIS: ADR is a complement, not a wholesale substitute, for independent courts.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: settlement systems risk pressure or unequal bargaining if consent is not real; specialised/local institutions need judges, staff, awareness and infrastructure; statutory finality cannot cure jurisdictional error or denial of natural justice; low utilisation or uneven State implementation may prevent designed access from becoming actual access.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: ANALYSIS: ADR is a complement, not a wholesale substitute, for independent courts.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The constitutional test is affordable access with voluntariness, fairness and review against illegality.

14. Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

14.1 Demand map

Demand	Answer spine
Lok Adalat significance	Art 39A -> statutory design -> consent/finality -> access gains -> safeguards
Ordinary versus PLA	jurisdiction -> stage -> conciliation -> merits power -> award
Alternative justice institutions	legal-services ladder -> four institutions -> comparative matrix -> implementation
Gram Nyayalayas	statutory design -> mobile/local jurisdiction -> appellate safeguard -> operational gaps
Family Courts	specialisation -> conciliation/privacy/flexibility -> fairness/capacity

14.2 Thesis options

- *Lok Adalats constitutionalise access through consensual settlement, but their legitimacy depends on genuine compromise rather than docket disposal.*
- *The Permanent Lok Adalat is a hybrid: conciliation remains first, but limited statutory adjudication follows failure in public-utility disputes.*
- *India's access-to-justice architecture is plural, yet statutory proximity must be matched by personnel, awareness and procedural fairness.*

14.3 Mark-scaled structures

Marks	Structure	Evidence
10	Art 39A -> design -> 2 distinctions -> verdict	3-4 statutory features
15	Institutional ladder -> ordinary/PLA comparison -> benefits/limits	5-6 anchors
20	Constitutional anchor -> four-institution matrix -> safeguards -> implementation reform -> conclusion	7-9 anchors

14.4 Evidence units

- **Claim:** an ordinary Lok Adalat is conciliatory, not adjudicatory. **Evidence:** □ compromise design and award provisions. **Analysis:** consent legitimises finality. **Qualification:** limited constitutional challenge remains.
- **Claim:** PLA fills a pre-litigation public-service gap. **Evidence:** □ public-utility and post-conciliation merits powers. **Analysis:** combines settlement with enforceable resolution. **Qualification:** jurisdiction is sectoral and notification-sensitive.
- **Claim:** proximity alone does not ensure justice. **Evidence:** □ mobile Gram Nyayalaya design. **Analysis:** reduces distance. **Qualification:** State establishment, staffing and awareness determine actual access.

SESSION 14 - MUST-KNOW FACTS AND TRAPS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: FACT: Art 39A is the constitutional anchor. □ Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates the authority ladder and Lok Adalats. □ Ordinary Lok Adalat cannot decide merits after failed compromise. □ PLA may decide merits after failed conciliation in eligible public-utility disputes. □ Both awards are treated as civil-court decrees and are final/binding. □ Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas are statutory courts with adjudicatory power. □ Fast Track Courts and evening courts are designs/schemes; special and commercial courts derive jurisdiction from their governing law. □ Mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat and PLA have different consent and merits-decision rules. **ANALYSIS:** Current pecuniary limits, notified services and operational counts require dated official verification.

Technical definition: Technically, Must-Know Facts and traps is analysed by relating Must-Know Facts to traps, then testing the relationship through Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 and FACT: Art 39A.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

FACT: Art 39A is the constitutional anchor. □ Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates the authority ladder and Lok Adalats. □ Ordinary Lok Adalat cannot decide merits after failed compromise. □ PLA may decide merits after failed conciliation in eligible public-utility disputes. □ Both awards are treated as civil-court decrees and are final/binding. □ Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas are statutory courts with adjudicatory power. □ Fast Track Courts and evening courts are designs/schemes; special and commercial courts derive jurisdiction from their governing law. □ Mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat and PLA have different consent and merits-decision rules. ANALYSIS: Current pecuniary limits, notified services and operational counts require dated official verification.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Must-Know Facts**
- **traps**
- **Legal Services Authorities Act 1987**
- **FACT: Art 39A**
- **Art**
- **Legal Services Authorities Act**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Must-Know Facts; define traps, connect Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 with FACT: Art 39A to explain the mechanism, and use Art for the decisive comparison or qualification.

- FACT: Art 39A is the constitutional anchor.
- □ Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates the authority ladder and Lok Adalats.
- □ Ordinary Lok Adalat cannot decide merits after failed compromise.
- □ PLA may decide merits after failed conciliation in eligible public-utility disputes.
- □ Both awards are treated as civil-court decrees and are final/binding.
- □ Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas are statutory courts with adjudicatory power.
- □ Fast Track Courts and evening courts are designs/schemes; special and commercial courts derive jurisdiction from their governing law.
- □ Mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat and PLA have different consent and merits-decision rules.
- ANALYSIS: Current pecuniary limits, notified services and operational counts require dated official verification.

Source discipline

- Never use "people's court" to imply absence of law or fairness.
- Do not say all Lok Adalat disputes are pre-litigation.
- Do not say no legal challenge of any kind can ever lie against an award.
- Do not merge Permanent Lok Adalat with an ordinary permanent sitting.
- Do not call Gram Nyayalaya a Panchayat institution.

Cross-links

- High Court supervision/review: [High-Court.md](#)
- Tribunals and specialised adjudication: [Administrative-Tribunals.md](#)
- Statutory/quasi-judicial bodies: [Statutory-Regulatory-and-Quasi-Judicial-Bodies.md](#)
- DPSP context: [Directive-Principles.md](#)

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - MUST-KNOW FACTS AND TRAPS

START / CONCEPT: Must-Know Facts and traps

|
v

EXACT TERMS: Must-Know Facts · traps · Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 · FACT: Art 39A · Art · Legal Services Authorities Act

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Never use "people's court" to imply absence of law or fairness.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Do not say no legal challenge of any kind can ever lie against an award.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not merge Permanent Lok Adalat with an ordinary permanent sitting.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: FACT: Art 39A is the constitutional anchor. Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates the authority ladder and Lok Adalats. Ordinary Lok Adalat cannot decide merits after failed compromise. PLA may decide merits after failed conciliation in eligible public-utility disputes. Both awards are treated as civil-court decrees and are final/binding. Family Courts and Gram Nyayalayas are statutory courts with adjudicatory power. Fast Track Courts and evening courts are designs/schemes; special and commercial courts derive jurisdiction from their governing law. Mediation, ordinary Lok Adalat and PLA have different consent and merits-decision rules. ANALYSIS: Current pecuniary limits, notified services and operational counts require dated official verification.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1. What is the constitutional anchor for equal access and free legal aid?

- A. Article 39A directs the State to promote justice on equal opportunity and prevent economic or other disability from denying access.
- B. Article 50 establishes Lok Adalats.
- C. Article 136 guarantees free counsel in every dispute.
- D. Article 32 creates every legal-services authority.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 39A is a Directive Principle operationalised through statutes and Article 21 jurisprudence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 2. Which institutional description is accurate?

- A. SALSA is the statutory name of every State authority.
- B. NALSA, the Supreme Court Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and TLSCs perform level-specific legal-services functions.
- C. DLSAs are constitutional courts.
- D. TLSCs may overrule High Court decisions.

Answer: B

Explanation: The 1987 Act creates a coordinated statutory ladder; SLSA is the ordinary abbreviation. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 3. Which statement about free legal-services eligibility is correct?

- A. OBC status by itself is expressly listed in Section 12.
- B. Every senior citizen qualifies solely by age under Section 12.
- C. Eligibility includes several status-based vulnerable categories as well as prescribed income criteria, subject also to a prima facie case assessment.
- D. Only persons below an income ceiling qualify.

Answer: C

Explanation: SC/ST members, women/children, persons in custody and other listed groups do not depend solely on income. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 4. Which matter may an ordinary Lok Adalat handle?

- A. A matter outside all ordinary court jurisdiction.
- B. Only disputes already decided by a High Court.
- C. Every criminal offence regardless of compoundability.
- D. A pending case or pre-litigation dispute within a court's jurisdiction, excluding a non-compoundable offence.

Answer: D

Explanation: Sections 19-20 combine pending and pre-litigation settlement jurisdiction with a criminal-law exclusion. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 5. What may an ordinary Lok Adalat do when settlement fails?

- A. It must not decide the merits; a referred pending case returns to court and parties retain the ordinary remedy.
- B. It may compel one party to accept the proposed terms.
- C. It converts automatically into a Permanent Lok Adalat.
- D. It must impose an equitable merits award.

Answer: A

Explanation: State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008) confirms the compromise-only character. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 6. Which statement about an agreed Lok Adalat award is correct?

- A. The award is only a non-binding recommendation.
- B. It is deemed a civil-court decree, final and binding, and no statutory appeal lies; limited constitutional challenge remains for jurisdictional or consent defects.
- C. Finality validates an award imposed without settlement.
- D. Any dissatisfied party may appeal on facts.

Answer: B

Explanation: Consent supports statutory finality but does not eliminate constitutional review for illegality. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 7. Which feature defines a Permanent Lok Adalat?

- A. It hears every pending civil suit transferred by a court.
- B. It is merely a continuously sitting ordinary Lok Adalat.
- C. It is a standing pre-litigation forum for notified public utility services under Chapter VI-A.
- D. It may try non-compoundable offences.

Answer: C

Explanation: Sector, stage and statutory exclusions define PLA competence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 8. When may a PLA decide an eligible dispute on merits?

- A. Never; all Lok Adalats are compromise-only.
- B. Only with a fresh arbitral agreement.
- C. Before attempting conciliation.
- D. After conducting the statutory conciliation process and failing to secure settlement, subject to jurisdictional limits.

Answer: D

Explanation: Bar Council of India (2012) and Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama (2022) support the conciliation-cum-adjudication design. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 9. Which statement about a Gram Nyayalaya is correct?

- A. It is a statutory mobile-capable court of first instance with scheduled civil/criminal jurisdiction and appellate routes.
- B. Its awards are unappealable compromises.
- C. It is constitutionally mandatory in every Panchayat.
- D. It is a village panchayat exercising customary power.

Answer: A

Explanation: The 2008 Act creates a judicial forum; establishment and operation remain State-dependent. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 10. Which feature distinguishes a Family Court?

- A. It can only record compromises.
- B. It combines specialised statutory adjudication with a duty to explore settlement, privacy tools and a defined High Court appeal.
- C. Lawyers have an unconditional right of appearance as of course.
- D. It is an arbitral tribunal chosen by contract.

Answer: B

Explanation: Conciliation orientation does not remove adjudicatory power or fairness duties. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 11. Which classification is accurate?

- A. Every special court is a tribunal outside the judiciary.
- B. Both are new constitutional tiers.
- C. Fast-track courts are capacity/administrative schemes, while special courts obtain jurisdiction from a parent statute or valid notification.
- D. An evening court has nationwide statutory jurisdiction.

Answer: C

Explanation: Labels do not answer source, appointment, procedure or appeal. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 12. Which comparison is legally correct?

- A. All four can decide non-compoundable criminal offences.
- B. Every outcome has the same appeal and enforcement route.
- C. All four require an identical prior contract.
- D. Mediation produces a party-made settlement, arbitration produces an adjudicatory award, ordinary Lok Adalat records compromise, and a PLA has limited post-conciliation merits power.

Answer: D

Explanation: Consent, jurisdiction, decision-maker and legal effect differ across dispute-resolution designs. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 13. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning Article 39A?

- A. Article 39A directs the State to promote justice on equal opportunity and prevent economic or other disability from denying access.
- B. Article 32 creates every legal-services authority.
- C. Article 136 guarantees free counsel in every dispute.
- D. Article 50 establishes Lok Adalats.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 39A is a Directive Principle operationalised through statutes and Article 21 jurisprudence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 14. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning the legal-services ladder?

- A. DLSAs are constitutional courts.
- B. NALSA, the Supreme Court Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and TLSCs perform level-specific legal-services functions.
- C. SALSA is the statutory name of every State authority.
- D. TLSCs may overrule High Court decisions.

Answer: B

Explanation: The 1987 Act creates a coordinated statutory ladder; SLISA is the ordinary abbreviation. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 15. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning Section 12 eligibility?

- A. OBC status by itself is expressly listed in Section 12.
- B. Every senior citizen qualifies solely by age under Section 12.
- C. Eligibility includes several status-based vulnerable categories as well as prescribed income criteria, subject also to a prima facie case assessment.
- D. Only persons below an income ceiling qualify.

Answer: C

Explanation: SC/ST members, women/children, persons in custody and other listed groups do not depend solely on income. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 16. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning ordinary Lok Adalat jurisdiction?

- A. Every criminal offence regardless of compoundability.
- B. Only disputes already decided by a High Court.
- C. A matter outside all ordinary court jurisdiction.
- D. A pending case or pre-litigation dispute within a court's jurisdiction, excluding a non-compoundable offence.

Answer: D

Explanation: Sections 19-20 combine pending and pre-litigation settlement jurisdiction with a criminal-law exclusion. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 17. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning ordinary Lok Adalat power?

- A. It must not decide the merits; a referred pending case returns to court and parties retain the ordinary remedy.
- B. It must impose an equitable merits award.
- C. It converts automatically into a Permanent Lok Adalat.
- D. It may compel one party to accept the proposed terms.

Answer: A

Explanation: State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008) confirms the compromise-only character. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 18. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning ordinary Lok Adalat awards?

- A. Any dissatisfied party may appeal on facts.
- B. It is deemed a civil-court decree, final and binding, and no statutory appeal lies; limited constitutional challenge remains for jurisdictional or consent defects.
- C. Finality validates an award imposed without settlement.
- D. The award is only a non-binding recommendation.

Answer: B

Explanation: Consent supports statutory finality but does not eliminate constitutional review for illegality. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 19. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning Permanent Lok Adalat jurisdiction?

- A. It hears every pending civil suit transferred by a court.
- B. It is merely a continuously sitting ordinary Lok Adalat.
- C. It is a standing pre-litigation forum for notified public utility services under Chapter VI-A.
- D. It may try non-compoundable offences.

Answer: C

Explanation: Sector, stage and statutory exclusions define PLA competence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 20. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning Permanent Lok Adalat merits power?

- A. Never; all Lok Adalats are compromise-only.
- B. Before attempting conciliation.
- C. Only with a fresh arbitral agreement.
- D. After conducting the statutory conciliation process and failing to secure settlement, subject to jurisdictional limits.

Answer: D

Explanation: Bar Council of India (2012) and Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama (2022) support the conciliation-cum-adjudication design. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 21. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning Gram Nyayalayas?

- A. It is a statutory mobile-capable court of first instance with scheduled civil/criminal jurisdiction and appellate routes.
- B. It is a village panchayat exercising customary power.
- C. It is constitutionally mandatory in every Panchayat.
- D. Its awards are unappealable compromises.

Answer: A

Explanation: The 2008 Act creates a judicial forum; establishment and operation remain State-dependent. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 22. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning Family Courts?

- A. It is an arbitral tribunal chosen by contract.
- B. It combines specialised statutory adjudication with a duty to explore settlement, privacy tools and a defined High Court appeal.
- C. It can only record compromises.
- D. Lawyers have an unconditional right of appearance as of course.

Answer: B

Explanation: Conciliation orientation does not remove adjudicatory power or fairness duties. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 23. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning fast-track and special courts?

- A. An evening court has nationwide statutory jurisdiction.
- B. Both are new constitutional tiers.
- C. Fast-track courts are capacity/administrative schemes, while special courts obtain jurisdiction from a parent statute or valid notification.
- D. Every special court is a tribunal outside the judiciary.

Answer: C

Explanation: Labels do not answer source, appointment, procedure or appeal. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 24. Which close-option distinction is constitutionally accurate concerning mediation, arbitration and Lok Adalat?

- A. All four can decide non-compoundable criminal offences.
- B. All four require an identical prior contract.
- C. Every outcome has the same appeal and enforcement route.
- D. Mediation produces a party-made settlement, arbitration produces an adjudicatory award, ordinary Lok Adalat records compromise, and a PLA has limited post-conciliation merits power.

Answer: D

Explanation: Consent, jurisdiction, decision-maker and legal effect differ across dispute-resolution designs. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 25. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. Article 39A directs the State to promote justice on equal opportunity and prevent economic or other disability from denying access.
- B. Article 50 establishes Lok Adalats.
- C. Article 136 guarantees free counsel in every dispute.
- D. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 39A is a Directive Principle operationalised through statutes and Article 21 jurisprudence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 26. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. DLSAs are constitutional courts.
- B. NALSA, the Supreme Court Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and TLSCs perform level-specific legal-services functions.
- C. TLSCs may overrule High Court decisions.
- D. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.

Answer: B

Explanation: The 1987 Act creates a coordinated statutory ladder; SLSC is the ordinary abbreviation. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 27. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- B. OBC status by itself is expressly listed in Section 12.
- C. Eligibility includes several status-based vulnerable categories as well as prescribed income criteria, subject also to a prima facie case assessment.
- D. Every senior citizen qualifies solely by age under Section 12.

Answer: C

Explanation: SC/ST members, women/children, persons in custody and other listed groups do not depend solely on income. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 28. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. A matter outside all ordinary court jurisdiction.
- B. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- C. Every criminal offence regardless of compoundability.
- D. A pending case or pre-litigation dispute within a court's jurisdiction, excluding a non-compoundable offence.

Answer: D

Explanation: Sections 19-20 combine pending and pre-litigation settlement jurisdiction with a criminal-law exclusion. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 29. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. It must not decide the merits; a referred pending case returns to court and parties retain the ordinary remedy.
- B. It converts automatically into a Permanent Lok Adalat.
- C. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- D. It may compel one party to accept the proposed terms.

Answer: A

Explanation: State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008) confirms the compromise-only character. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 30. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- B. It is deemed a civil-court decree, final and binding, and no statutory appeal lies; limited constitutional challenge remains for jurisdictional or consent defects.
- C. Finality validates an award imposed without settlement.
- D. The award is only a non-binding recommendation.

Answer: B

Explanation: Consent supports statutory finality but does not eliminate constitutional review for illegality. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 31. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. It may try non-compoundable offences.
- B. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- C. It is a standing pre-litigation forum for notified public utility services under Chapter VI-A.
- D. It is merely a continuously sitting ordinary Lok Adalat.

Answer: C

Explanation: Sector, stage and statutory exclusions define PLA competence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 32. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. Only with a fresh arbitral agreement.
- B. Never; all Lok Adalats are compromise-only.
- C. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- D. After conducting the statutory conciliation process and failing to secure settlement, subject to jurisdictional limits.

Answer: D

Explanation: Bar Council of India (2012) and Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama (2022) support the conciliation-cum-adjudication design. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 33. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. It is a statutory mobile-capable court of first instance with scheduled civil/criminal jurisdiction and appellate routes.
- B. Its awards are unappealable compromises.
- C. It is constitutionally mandatory in every Panchayat.
- D. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.

Answer: A

Explanation: The 2008 Act creates a judicial forum; establishment and operation remain State-dependent. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 34. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- B. It combines specialised statutory adjudication with a duty to explore settlement, privacy tools and a defined High Court appeal.
- C. Lawyers have an unconditional right of appearance as of course.
- D. It is an arbitral tribunal chosen by contract.

Answer: B

Explanation: Conciliation orientation does not remove adjudicatory power or fairness duties. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 35. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. An evening court has nationwide statutory jurisdiction.
- B. Every special court is a tribunal outside the judiciary.
- C. Fast-track courts are capacity/administrative schemes, while special courts obtain jurisdiction from a parent statute or valid notification.
- D. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.

Answer: C

Explanation: Labels do not answer source, appointment, procedure or appeal. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 36. A State authority adopts the following proposition. Which correction is legally safest?

- A. The proposition is valid because all affirmative-action powers are interchangeable.
- B. All four require an identical prior contract.
- C. Every outcome has the same appeal and enforcement route.
- D. Mediation produces a party-made settlement, arbitration produces an adjudicatory award, ordinary Lok Adalat records compromise, and a PLA has limited post-conciliation merits power.

Answer: D

Explanation: Consent, jurisdiction, decision-maker and legal effect differ across dispute-resolution designs. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 37. For a UPSC answer on Article 39A, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. Article 39A directs the State to promote justice on equal opportunity and prevent economic or other disability from denying access.
- B. Article 32 creates every legal-services authority.
- C. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- D. Article 50 establishes Lok Adalats.

Answer: A

Explanation: Article 39A is a Directive Principle operationalised through statutes and Article 21 jurisprudence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 38. For a UPSC answer on the legal-services ladder, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- B. NALSA, the Supreme Court Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and TLSCs perform level-specific legal-services functions.
- C. TLSCs may overrule High Court decisions.
- D. SALSA is the statutory name of every State authority.

Answer: B

Explanation: The 1987 Act creates a coordinated statutory ladder; SLISA is the ordinary abbreviation. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 39. For a UPSC answer on Section 12 eligibility, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. OBC status by itself is expressly listed in Section 12.
- B. Only persons below an income ceiling qualify.
- C. Eligibility includes several status-based vulnerable categories as well as prescribed income criteria, subject also to a prima facie case assessment.
- D. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.

Answer: C

Explanation: SC/ST members, women/children, persons in custody and other listed groups do not depend solely on income. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 40. For a UPSC answer on ordinary Lok Adalat jurisdiction, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. Only disputes already decided by a High Court.
- B. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- C. A matter outside all ordinary court jurisdiction.
- D. A pending case or pre-litigation dispute within a court's jurisdiction, excluding a non-compoundable offence.

Answer: D

Explanation: Sections 19-20 combine pending and pre-litigation settlement jurisdiction with a criminal-law exclusion. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 41. For a UPSC answer on ordinary Lok Adalat power, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. It must not decide the merits; a referred pending case returns to court and parties retain the ordinary remedy.
- B. It must impose an equitable merits award.
- C. It may compel one party to accept the proposed terms.
- D. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.

Answer: A

Explanation: State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008) confirms the compromise-only character. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 42. For a UPSC answer on ordinary Lok Adalat awards, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. Any dissatisfied party may appeal on facts.
- B. It is deemed a civil-court decree, final and binding, and no statutory appeal lies; limited constitutional challenge remains for jurisdictional or consent defects.
- C. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- D. Finality validates an award imposed without settlement.

Answer: B

Explanation: Consent supports statutory finality but does not eliminate constitutional review for illegality. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 43. For a UPSC answer on Permanent Lok Adalat jurisdiction, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. It may try non-compoundable offences.
- B. It hears every pending civil suit transferred by a court.
- C. It is a standing pre-litigation forum for notified public utility services under Chapter VI-A.
- D. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.

Answer: C

Explanation: Sector, stage and statutory exclusions define PLA competence. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 44. For a UPSC answer on Permanent Lok Adalat merits power, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. Before attempting conciliation.
- B. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- C. Never; all Lok Adalats are compromise-only.
- D. After conducting the statutory conciliation process and failing to secure settlement, subject to jurisdictional limits.

Answer: D

Explanation: Bar Council of India (2012) and Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama (2022) support the conciliation-cum-adjudication design. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 45. For a UPSC answer on Gram Nyayalayas, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. It is a statutory mobile-capable court of first instance with scheduled civil/criminal jurisdiction and appellate routes.
- B. It is a village panchayat exercising customary power.
- C. It is constitutionally mandatory in every Panchayat.
- D. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.

Answer: A

Explanation: The 2008 Act creates a judicial forum; establishment and operation remain State-dependent. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 46. For a UPSC answer on Family Courts, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. Lawyers have an unconditional right of appearance as of course.
- B. It combines specialised statutory adjudication with a duty to explore settlement, privacy tools and a defined High Court appeal.
- C. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- D. It can only record compromises.

Answer: B

Explanation: Conciliation orientation does not remove adjudicatory power or fairness duties. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 47. For a UPSC answer on fast-track and special courts, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. An evening court has nationwide statutory jurisdiction.
- B. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- C. Fast-track courts are capacity/administrative schemes, while special courts obtain jurisdiction from a parent statute or valid notification.
- D. Both are new constitutional tiers.

Answer: C

Explanation: Labels do not answer source, appointment, procedure or appeal. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

MCQ 48. For a UPSC answer on mediation, arbitration and Lok Adalat, which proposition should anchor the analysis?

- A. All four can decide non-compoundable criminal offences.
- B. The issue is controlled only by executive policy and not constitutional text.
- C. Every outcome has the same appeal and enforcement route.
- D. Mediation produces a party-made settlement, arbitration produces an adjudicatory award, ordinary Lok Adalat records compromise, and a PLA has limited post-conciliation merits power.

Answer: D

Explanation: Consent, jurisdiction, decision-maker and legal effect differ across dispute-resolution designs. The other options confuse the legal source, institution, beneficiary-identification rule, benefit-conferral rule or current-status gate.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims 2020, GS Paper I, Question 9

Exact question: In India, Legal Services Authorities provide free legal services to which of the following type of citizens?

1. Person with an annual income of less than Rs. 1,00,000
 2. Transgender with an annual income of less than Rs. 2,00,000
 3. Member of Other Backward Classes (OBC) with an annual income of less than Rs. 3,00,000
 4. All Senior Citizens
- A. 1 and 2 only
 - B. 3 and 4 only
 - C. 2 and 3 only
 - D. 1 and 4 only

Verified answer: A, reconciled with the applicable legal-services eligibility framework; no official UPSC key is claimed from the repository.

Verified PYQ 2 - UPSC Mains 2023, GS Paper II, Question 2

Exact question: "Who are entitled to receive free legal aid? Assess the role of the National Legal Services Authority (NALSA) in rendering free legal aid in India." **10 marks, 150 words.**

Model answer: Article 39A directs equal access to justice and the Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 converts that objective into institutions and entitlements. Section 12 covers SC/ST members, women and children, trafficking/beggar victims, persons with disability, disaster or violence victims, industrial workmen, persons in custody and persons below the prescribed income limit, subject to a prima facie case. NALSA lays down policy, frames economical schemes, coordinates State Authorities, supports Lok Adalats and legal-awareness programmes, and monitors delivery through the statutory ladder. Its strength is national coordination; its limits are uneven awareness, counsel quality, vacancies, distance and digital exclusion. NALSA should therefore be assessed not only by beneficiary counts but by timely advice, representation quality and durable case outcomes.

Why this earns marks: It answers both entitlement and institutional role. **How to improve:** Name Section 12 and distinguish NALSA from SLASA/DLSA implementation. **Compression:** 30 words on law, 85 on role and 30 on limits/verdict.

Verified PYQ 3 - UPSC Mains 2024, GS Paper II, Question 2

Exact printed wording: "Explain and distinguish between Lok Adalats and Arbitration Tribunals, Whether they entertain civil as well as criminal cases?" **10 marks, 150 words.**

Model answer: Lok Adalats are statutory settlement forums under the Legal Services Authorities Act. An ordinary Lok Adalat may consider pending or pre-litigation civil disputes and compoundable criminal matters, but cannot adjudicate merits when compromise fails. Its agreed award is deemed a civil-court decree, final and non-appealable. An arbitral tribunal derives jurisdiction from an arbitration agreement and the Arbitration and Conciliation Act; it adjudicates arbitrable civil or commercial disputes and issues a reasoned award subject to the statutory setting-aside and appeal framework. Criminal liability is generally non-arbitrable, whereas a Lok Adalat can settle a compoundable criminal case. A Permanent Lok Adalat is a separate public-utility pre-litigation hybrid and should not be used to describe every Lok Adalat.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes source, consent, jurisdiction, merits power and review. **How to improve:** Preserve the paper's printed spellings only in the quotation, then use correct legal terminology. **Compression:** two 50-word forum capsules and a 30-word criminal-case verdict.

Original solved Mains practice

M1. Explain the constitutional and statutory architecture of free legal services in India.

Directive: Explain | **Marks:** 10 | **Answer in:** 150 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: Article 39A supplies the equal-access objective, while Article 21 jurisprudence treats effective legal assistance and speedy justice as elements of fair procedure. The Legal Services Authorities Act 1987 creates NALSA, the Supreme Court Legal Services Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and TLSCs. Section 12 combines status-based vulnerability with income eligibility and a prima facie case screen. NALSA frames policy and schemes; State and district institutions translate them into representation, advice, awareness and Lok Adalat access. The architecture is therefore vertically coordinated but delivery-dependent. Its constitutional success must be measured by early advice, competent counsel, language/disability access and actual outcomes rather than formal eligibility alone.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 85 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M2. Distinguish ordinary Lok Adalats from Permanent Lok Adalats.

Directive: Distinguish | **Marks:** 15 | **Answer in:** 250 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: An ordinary Lok Adalat under Chapter VI handles pending or pre-litigation disputes within court jurisdiction, excluding non-compoundable offences. It conciliates only; State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008) confirms that it cannot decide merits after failure. A PLA under Chapter VI-A is a standing pre-litigation forum limited to public utility services. It must first conciliate, but may adjudicate an eligible dispute after conciliation fails, as sustained in Bar Council of India v. Union of India (2012). Both awards are final, binding and deemed civil-court decrees, yet their jurisdictional basis differs. The core distinction is not permanence alone but sector, stage and post-failure decisional power.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 175 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M3. Critically assess finality and consent in Lok Adalat awards.

Directive: Critically assess | **Marks:** 15 | **Answer in:** 250 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: Statutory finality makes an agreed Lok Adalat award enforceable as a civil-court decree and prevents routine appeals, reducing delay and preserving settlements. Its legitimacy, however, derives from genuine compromise. An ordinary Lok Adalat cannot use docket pressure, unequal bargaining or an adjudicatory opinion to manufacture consent. Where compromise fails, a pending case returns to court. A writ challenge may remain on narrow grounds such as fraud, absence of consent, jurisdictional error or denial of natural justice. PLA awards involve a different statutory design because eligible disputes may be decided after failed conciliation. Finality should therefore be defended as settlement enforcement, not as insulation of coercion or illegality.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 175 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M4. Evaluate Permanent Lok Adalats as public-utility justice institutions.

Directive: Evaluate | **Marks:** 20 | **Answer in:** 250 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: Permanent Lok Adalats address recurring pre-litigation disputes in notified public utility services such as transport, power, water, sanitation, hospitals and insurance. Their sequence-application, conciliation, proposed settlement and, on failure, limited merits adjudication-offers an enforceable remedy without requiring ordinary litigation. *Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama* (2022) stresses fidelity to the conciliation procedure. Benefits include low cost, sector focus and early resolution; risks include jurisdictional overreach, weak legal assistance and confusing PLA adjudication with ordinary Lok Adalat compromise. Pecuniary limits and notified services are date-sensitive and must be verified. PLAs are valuable when competence, procedural fairness, reasoned decision and constitutional review operate together.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 175 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M5. Discuss the design and implementation challenges of Gram Nyayalayas.

Directive: Discuss | **Marks:** 15 | **Answer in:** 250 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: The Gram Nyayalayas Act 2008 envisages rural first-instance courts at intermediate-Panchayat or grouped-Panchayat level, a Nyayadhikari qualified as a Judicial Magistrate First Class, mobile sittings, scheduled civil/criminal jurisdiction, conciliation and appeals to District or Sessions Courts. This design reduces distance and procedural cost while preserving judicial character. Yet establishment is State-dependent and proximity without

judges, staff, awareness, transport, language support and coordination with police/legal aid cannot deliver access. Gram Nyayalayas must not be confused with Panchayats or Lok Adalats. Reform requires rational jurisdiction mapping, regular mobile calendars, DLSA integration and transparent dated performance data.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 175 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M6. Compare Family Courts, fast-track courts, special courts and commercial courts.

Directive: Compare | **Marks:** 15 | **Answer in:** 250 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: Family Courts derive from the 1984 Act and combine specialised adjudication with settlement, privacy and flexible evidentiary reception. Fast-track courts are additional-capacity schemes implemented through States and High Courts rather than a distinct constitutional tier. Special courts obtain subject or offence jurisdiction from a parent statute/notification. Commercial Courts are statutory civil courts using specified-value jurisdiction, case management and pre-institution mediation rules. Therefore the labels cannot be interchanged: source determines judges, jurisdiction, procedure, appeal and permanence. Specialisation can improve expertise and speed, but only adequate staffing and fair process prevent a faster forum from becoming a weaker one.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 175 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M7. Analyse power asymmetry and digital exclusion in settlement-oriented justice.

Directive: Analyse | **Marks:** 20 | **Answer in:** 250 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: Settlement systems lower cost and preserve relationships, but apparent consent may conceal unequal bargaining between insurer and victim, employer and worker, institution and consumer, or digitally connected and excluded parties. Fair design requires independent legal advice, understandable terms, interpreter and disability support, private communication, time to reflect and a clear record of consent. E-Lok Adalats and online mediation reduce travel but need identity assurance, secure documents, language access and an offline alternative. Disposal volume cannot be the sole metric. Durable compliance, informed consent and equitable outcomes better express Article 39A.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 175 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

M8. Design a forum-selection test for an access-to-justice problem.

Directive: Design | **Marks:** 10 | **Answer in:** 150 words.

Demand decode: Define the exact constitutional issue, organise by legal source and effect, use named evidence, confront the strongest limit and reach a qualified verdict.

Model answer: Ask five questions. First, is coercive interim relief or authoritative precedent required? If yes, use a competent court. Second, is settlement voluntary and relationship-preserving? Consider mediation or ordinary Lok Adalat. Third, is it a pre-litigation public-utility dispute within PLA limits? Use the PLA sequence. Fourth, is local first-instance civil/criminal jurisdiction under the Gram Nyayalayas Act available? Fifth, is specialist statutory jurisdiction-family, commercial or offence-specific-triggered? Then verify appeal, legal aid, limitation, current notification and digital/offline access. Forum follows legal competence and fairness, not disposal targets.

Why this earns marks: The answer follows claim -> named Article/amendment/case -> analysis -> qualification and directly obeys the directive.

How to improve: Convert the first sentence into a precise thesis, underline the controlling Articles/cases and reserve the final two sentences for a graded conclusion.

Compression plan: 20-25 words of introduction, 85 words of organised analysis and 25-35 words of qualified conclusion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Companion to basic/Lok-Adalats-and-Other-Courts.md. Apply only after the complete statutory and comparative Core.

Dispute-system design

A justice system should match forum to dispute:

Dispute characteristic	Suitable design consideration
Continuing relationship	conciliation/mediation with consent safeguards
Urgent coercive relief	court with enforceable interim jurisdiction
Technical recurring field	specialised court/tribunal with review
Low-value local claim	accessible first-instance forum and simplified procedure
Public-utility pre-litigation dispute	PLA only within statutory jurisdiction

No forum should be chosen merely to improve disposal statistics.

Consent quality and power asymmetry

Settlement legitimacy requires informed consent, access to advice, absence of intimidation, understanding of consequences and neutral facilitation. Women, workers, accident victims, consumers and persons with limited digital access may face unequal bargaining power. A signed settlement is therefore not the end of the fairness inquiry where fraud, coercion or jurisdictional defect is credibly alleged.

Digital justice

E-Lok Adalats and online mediation can reduce travel and scheduling cost, but require identity assurance, private communication, document access, language support, disability access and an offline alternative. Digital convenience must not become a condition for accessing justice.

Reform metrics

Evaluate access institutions by:

- time and cost saved;
- representation and informed-consent quality;
- settlement durability and compliance;
- geographic and social reach;
- reasoned handling of failed settlement;
- staffing, infrastructure and legal-aid quality; and

- review of jurisdictional or natural-justice error.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Forum and effect map

- **Article 39A:** Article 39A directs the State to promote justice on equal opportunity and prevent economic or other disability from denying access.
- **the legal-services ladder:** NALSA, the Supreme Court Committee, SLSAs, High Court Committees, DLSAs and TLSCs perform level-specific legal-services functions.
- **Section 12 eligibility:** Eligibility includes several status-based vulnerable categories as well as prescribed income criteria, subject also to a prima facie case assessment.
- **ordinary Lok Adalat jurisdiction:** A pending case or pre-litigation dispute within a court's jurisdiction, excluding a non-compoundable offence.
- **ordinary Lok Adalat power:** It must not decide the merits; a referred pending case returns to court and parties retain the ordinary remedy.
- **ordinary Lok Adalat awards:** It is deemed a civil-court decree, final and binding, and no statutory appeal lies; limited constitutional challenge remains for jurisdictional or consent defects.
- **Permanent Lok Adalat jurisdiction:** It is a standing pre-litigation forum for notified public utility services under Chapter VI-A.
- **Permanent Lok Adalat merits power:** After conducting the statutory conciliation process and failing to secure settlement, subject to jurisdictional limits.
- **Gram Nyayalayas:** It is a statutory mobile-capable court of first instance with scheduled civil/criminal jurisdiction and appellate routes.
- **Family Courts:** It combines specialised statutory adjudication with a duty to explore settlement, privacy tools and a defined High Court appeal.
- **fast-track and special courts:** Fast-track courts are capacity/administrative schemes, while special courts obtain jurisdiction from a parent statute or valid notification.
- **mediation, arbitration and Lok Adalat:** Mediation produces a party-made settlement, arbitration produces an adjudicatory award, ordinary Lok Adalat records compromise, and a PLA has limited post-conciliation merits power.

Answer spine

Constitutional anchor -> statutory source -> institution -> stage and subject matter -> consent/merits power -> award -> appeal/review -> access safeguards -> dated status.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

High-yield use: Follow the panels as one topic-specific conceptual atlas: root question, classifications, processes or arguments, comparisons, objections and a final answer-writing spine. This text-native master is separate from both graphical flowchart artifacts.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Article 39A and the access-to-justice chain

ART 39A -> equal-opportunity justice + free legal aid.
Hussainara Khatoon (1979) -> Art 21 fair procedure, legal assistance and speedy justice.
1987 ACT -> institutions + eligibility + Lok Adalats.

VERDICT: Directive Principle becomes operational through law and remedies.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Legal-services authority ladder

NALSA -> national policy and schemes.
SUPREME COURT COMMITTEE -> Supreme Court matters.
SLSA + HIGH COURT COMMITTEE -> State/High Court delivery.
DLSA + TLSC -> district/taluk implementation.

TRAP: statutory SLSA, not SALSA; bodies are not constitutional courts.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Section 12 eligibility and quality gate

STATUS ROUTES -> SC/ST, women/children, disability, custody, workmen and listed vulnerability.
INCOME ROUTE -> prescribed ceiling.
SECTION 13 -> prima facie case.

QUALITY TEST: early advice + competent representation + accessible delivery.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Ordinary Lok Adalat jurisdiction

PENDING CASE or PRE-LITIGATION DISPUTE within court jurisdiction.
EXCLUDED -> non-compoundable offence.
PROCESS -> referral/application -> conciliation -> compromise.

State of Punjab v. Jalour Singh (2008): no merits adjudication.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Ordinary award, failure and review

SETTLEMENT -> award deemed civil-court decree -> final/binding -> no statutory appeal.
NO SETTLEMENT -> pending case returns / ordinary remedy continues.
WRIT CONTROL -> fraud, no genuine consent, jurisdiction or natural-justice defect.

FINALITY != power to compel compromise.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Permanent Lok Adalat jurisdiction

CHAPTER VI-A -> standing body for PUBLIC UTILITY SERVICES.
STAGE -> pre-litigation only.
BAR -> non-compoundable offence + notified pecuniary boundary.

InterGlobe Aviation v. N. Satchidanand (2011): ordinary and Permanent Lok Adalats differ.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: PLA conciliation-to-adjudication sequence

APPLICATION -> conciliation papers -> settlement terms -> agreement award.
IF FAILURE -> eligible merits decision.
Bar Council of India v. Union of India (2012) -> design upheld.
Canara Bank v. G.S. Jayarama (2022) -> follow statutory conciliation sequence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Gram Nyayalaya as a statutory court

2008 ACT -> State establishment after High Court consultation.
NYAYADHIKARI -> JMFC qualification.
MOBILE FIRST INSTANCE -> scheduled civil/criminal cases + conciliation.
APPEAL -> District Court / Sessions Court.

TRAP: not Panchayat, khap or Lok Adalat.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Family and specialist-court distinctions

FAMILY COURT -> adjudication + conciliation + privacy + High Court appeal.
FAST TRACK -> capacity scheme.
SPECIAL COURT -> parent-statute jurisdiction.
COMMERCIAL COURT -> statutory civil court and case management.
EVENING COURT -> administrative sitting format.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Mediation, arbitration and court firewall

Afcons Infrastructure v. Cherian Varkey Construction (2010) -> structured ADR referral.
MEDIATION -> party-made settlement.
ARBITRATION -> private adjudication and statutory award challenge.
ORDINARY LOK ADALAT -> compromise award.
PLA -> limited post-conciliation adjudication.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Fairness, data and digital access

Patil Automation v. Rakheja Engineers (2022)
-> mandatory commercial pre-institution mediation absent an urgent-relief exception.
CONSENT QUALITY -> advice + no coercion + understood terms.
DIGITAL -> identity, privacy, language, disability and offline option.
CURRENT DATA -> date every count, ceiling and notified service.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: UPSC forum-selection answer spine

- 1 LEGAL SOURCE.
- 2 SUBJECT / STAGE / COMPOUNDABILITY.
- 3 CONSENT OR MERITS POWER.
- 4 AWARD / APPEAL / REVIEW.
- 5 ACCESS AND POWER-ASYMMETRY SAFEGUARDS.

VERDICT: affordable justice must remain competent and voluntary where required.
Illegality remains reviewable.